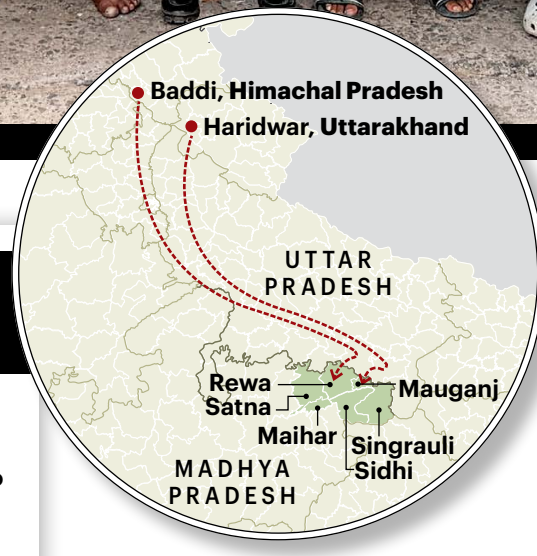


685

arrests under Op. Prahaar in 1.5 years in Rewa division



FLYING HIGH
From extreme left, a seized bottle of 'Off-Kuff' syrup; fake labels printed by a repackaging machine; the accused from the Gandhi Nagar, Bhopal bust

HOW THE SYRUP FLOWS

- **Racketeers register as authorised stockists/ distributors, allowing them to legally store commercial quantities of cough syrup**
- **Consignment moves from manufacturers in Baddi, Haridwar and other places to stockists' godowns, where peddlers book it under fake names**
- **Syrup diverted through contraband networks. Fake documentation, distorted labels/ batch numbers hinder traceability**
- **MRP for syrup is around Rs 150 per bottle, sold to addicts for up to Rs 500**

Rewa. The office of the drug controller is the main agency responsible for dealing with the misuse, but since there are inter-state issues involved, monitoring and control become a problem. "For the past few months, we have been working with a UP special task force (STF) which is taking action on their side," adds Rajput.

On the demand side, Rewa watchers propose an interesting reason for cough syrups being a popular fix. Caste and class consciousness still play a big role here in society, with alcohol consumption considered taboo, especially among the non-labouring castes. Cough syrups emit no odour and, outwardly, the addict appears sober. This helps many to stay high in the daytime too, with little negative impact on, say, jobs that are not too demanding. The theory may not be backed by any studies, but has many takers among the locals.

Also central to understanding the acuteness of the problem is also how Rewa has grown in the past couple of decades. The city did not have a passenger rail line till the 1990s. Enhanced connectivity, now with an airport added last year, has brought markers of prosperity in its wake. Neighbouring Singrauli district has seen the mushrooming of many mineral-based industries and is now being called the 'power capital' of central India—with a large number of generation units in and around it. All this development has had a trickledown effect across the landscape. Rewa now has flyovers, branded hotels and malls, something that would have been inconceivable even a decade ago. The sudden loss of the old